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# PREDICTABLE UNPREDICTABILITY

THERE'S A recently devised and statistically backed allegation about me that's been doing the rounds for years: Shahid Afridi does not push himself to perform often enough. It is also alleged that I am deliberately inconsistent in my batting and let my average slip until the exact moment where I'm out of options, cornered and, essentially, have an empty can left. A certain writer even called me 'a human ATM card', someone who knows exactly when he runs out of cash before refilling his account with a good knock.

In summary, the stats basically seem to suggest that only after a series of extreme lows do I give an impressive performance that gets my credit and ratings back to normal.

These aren't unfair allegations. And I'm not railing on about being the good guy and becoming self-critical here. While I admit that it is a correct assessment, I also regret not being consistent enough. Honestly, I wish I'd never given observers an opportunity to make such an assessment in the first place.

God has made everyone differently. He tests them in His own way, and they test themselves and fail Him or themselves in their own ways. But I'm lucky. I've always got the wake-up call at the right time. And whenever it has come, I've answered it and addressed the issue. So, in all fairness, I have performed.

Overconfidence is a strange thing. It leads to a certain sort of self-contentment, a sort of relaxation that gets to your head, which makes you say, 'I've been there, done that, and don't really need to do more.' Then one day, reality whacks you on the head and you wake up again.

This happens to a lot of players in sport; it happened to me too. Broadly, it's an issue of inconsistency, so obviously it's bad news for cricketers and their place in the team.

But I acknowledge that it is this inconsistency that has become a part of my style, and not necessarily in a positive way. Perhaps one way to look at it is that it is Shahid Afridi's own style and cricket would be boring if we all played and acted like each other, wouldn't it?

Of course, there are regrets. Although I lost myself to double-minded confusion – the focus